As the Sand Remembered

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COL-306601

Eternity From Long Ago

Sophia: 37, 37!

Sophia: Look at the trail I made in the water!

Thirty-seven: Yes, I was counting, the end result was the number 4.

37 walked over to Sophia, raising four fingers seriously.

Thirty-seven: That means what you did was spot on. "4" signifies justice and strength.

Sophia: Wonderful!

Sophia: Let me try again, I'll try to make more skips this time.

Sophia: One, two, three ...

Excitedly, Sophia picked up a few more smooth pebbles, only to receive a puzzled look from her companion.

Thirty-seven: You got the right answer already. Why throw more?

Sophia: ... ?

The question made Sophia pause, and she matched her puzzled face.

But 37 seemed to be the more confused.

Thirty-seven: Bigger numbers aren't always better. If you're testing your throwing technique, 4 is the best possible number.

Thirty-seven: Or do you want to test your passion and coordination? 5 would be better for that!

Sophia: No, I'm not trying to test any number ... It's a game ...

The red-haired girl felt caught in the awkwardness of the moment.

She hadn't been on the island for very long, and the seriousness with which they took arithmetic still left her feeling alien.

Thankfully, she had a companion who was well-versed in these matters.

Thirty-seven: A game ... Oh, a game!

Thirty-seven: Like kottabos, where you fling wine dregs from two-handled cups at dinner parties?

Sophia: ... I guess so. I mean it almost sounds like skipping stones ...

She had agreed without really understanding the specifics, but not wanting the conversation to stall.

... or to disappoint her new friend.

Thirty-seven: Ah ... alright.

Thirty-seven: I don't get the point of all this.

Sophia: Huh ... ?

37's brow furrowed—as if let down by her companion.

Thirty-seven: Throwing wine or pebbles, hitting a target, sinking a plate, or skipping stones on water —

Thirty-seven: What's the point of these actions? What are we trying to achieve?

Thirty-seven: If it's about being the highest-ranked, I get it. Like 210, he's always trying to get the top score in kottabos.

Thirty-seven: So is 6. He's always chasing the end of each series.

Thirty-seven: But sometimes it seems people do things without any purpose at all.

Sophia: Well, they're just playing.

Sophia: That's what most games are about—spending time with friends and having a fun time … without any greater purpose, I guess.

Thirty-seven: … Fun?

Thirty-seven: You mean … these things don't have any transcendent purpose?

Thirty-seven: They don't climb up the hierarchy, seek knowledge, purify their souls, or seek out the truth?

Thirty-seven: So all they're doing is idling in the sensory world.

The young girl's tone grew much more distant, even cynical, surprising Sophia.

Sophia: No, I think … well, it's not entirely like that …

Sophia: Sorry, 37 … I'm new here, and there's a lot I don't understand. If I'm wrong—

The blue-haired girl was resting her chin in her hands,she had already drifted away in thought.

Thirty-seven: Oh, sorry, what were you saying?

Thirty-seven: Never mind these trivial matters! We have more important things to do!

Thirty-seven: Mother asked me to familiarize you with the island. So, is 4 the number you wanted to validate on the beach?

Sophia: …

Sophia tried to finish her apology, but 37 dismissed it with a wave, she was already caught in another train of thought.

This kind of thing would happen several times until she got used to it.

But back then, her still-fledgling heart was unpolished by the sea breeze and sand, and she was full of questions.

Sophia: 37, I still don't quite understand … this"Apeiron" belief in numbers.

Sophia: Before coming here, I dealt with numbers in my studies, but it was just arithmetic.

Sophia: When I solved problems, my dad would reward me with a candy, and I'd save them in a jar to buy flowers for Mom before going to the hospital …

Thirty-seven: … ?

Sophia realized she was saying too much. It wasn't the right context, nor did it concern her new friend.

Sophia: … Anyway, my impression of numbers is all caught up in those textbook exercises. Far removed from these abstract, transcendent meanings.

Sophia: Like I don't understand, why you believe that numbers are eternal?

Thirty-seven: Because they are eternal!

37's answer, more a declaration, was yet more puzzling, making Sophia regret asking at all, and risking offense.

Thankfully, prime numbers like 37 are nimble-minded—at least that is what she would say.

Thirty-seven: I don't know how to explain it with words ... But I have the perfect example!

Thirty-seven: It was Euclid who once proved that there are an infinite number of prime numbers.

Sophia: Prime numbers ... Like how 37 is a prime number?

Thirty-seven: Yes, 13 is prime, 23 is prime, 37 is prime, and 337 is also prime! Their factors are only 1 and themselves. They cannot be divided by any other natural number.

Thirty-seven: Prime numbers can go on infinitely. But how can we prove this?

37 enthusiastically wrote a series of numbers in the sand, finishing with a circle at the end.

Thirty-seven: Euclid's method is to imagine the existence of the largest prime number—this is ○.

Thirty-seven: So, we make a complete series of prime numbers: starting from the smallest 2, all the way to the largest ○.

Thirty-seven: Based on this understanding, let's imagine there's a larger number, △.

Thirty-seven: △ represents the multiplication of all prime numbers in the queue, plus 1.

Thirty-seven: Clearly, it cannot be divided by any of the listed prime numbers. The numbers 2, 3, 5 ... or any number represented by ○ will result in a remainder of 1.

Thirty-seven: If △ is not a prime number, it should be divisible by a prime number larger than ○.

Thirty-seven: If △ is a prime number, then naturally it's larger than ○.

Thirty-seven: Both scenarios contradict the assumption that ○ is the largest prime number.

Thirty-seven: Therefore, the conclusion is—there's no such thing as the largest prime number ○. Prime numbers are infinite.

37 finished writing, clapped her hands, shook off the sand, and stood up beaming.

Sophia: I ... heard about this theorem at school. But I still don't understand what it means, really ...

She couldn't grasp the transcendental meaning behind such specific mathematical theorems.

To her, they were strict, correct, but nothing more than chalk particles on a blackboard, monochromatic, sharply defined, and barely soluble in water.

—And that was all.

Thirty-seven: ... Mother told me Euclid wrote down this proof over two thousand years ago.

Thirty-seven: She said, "The person who wrote this proof will die, the paper that recorded this proof will decompose, and we, who read this proof, will also one day disappear."

Thirty-seven: Everything will be washed away like sand on the seashore.

Thirty-seven: But this proof will endure, always correct, beautiful, and intricate, to be admired by every future generation.

Thirty-seven: —I suppose that's eternal.

Sophia: ... !

Thirty-seven: Everyone on the island tells me I'm special.

Thirty-seven: Prime numbers are like the foundation stones of arithmetic. All integers are derived from prime numbers.

Thirty-seven: But I'm one of a set of infinite prime numbers. There will always be more, newer numbers; so I'm not truly special.

Thirty-seven: But even if I am just 37 ... 37 grains of sand on the beach ... I'm still encompassed within this infinite queue.

Thirty-seven: —And there are an infinite number of such sequences! Sequences of integers, sequences of fractions, sequences of irrational numbers ... Each and every one infinite!

37 turned around, and now her eyes sparkled with the grains of sand in the sunlight.

Thirty-seven: We're all a part of infinity, and I take pride in that.

Thirty-seven: —I think, Sophia, that is what eternity is.

Under the bright sunlight, the grains of sand of the beach gleamed like gold. As she locked eyes with 37, it was blinding yet poignant.

Thirty-seven: "Don't close your eyes", as the scripture says, "Do not shy away from anything beautiful."

Sophia: Oh ...

Sophia: As time passed, I often remembered the theorem 37 told me.

Sophia: I never quite understood her world— this fascinating, abstract kingdom of mathematics where every number is her friend.

Sophia: But in that moment, I caught a fleeting glimpse of the beautiful brilliance of "eternity" in her eyes.

Sophia: It was enchanting ... inspiring and admirable.

Sophia: It became the seed that led me to embrace the school.

Sophia: The beach changed in the days that followed.

Sophia: The ship approached the shore, the "Emanation" unfolded before our eyes, and cheers turned into sorrowful cries.

Sophia: Eventually, all that remained of what we lost were cold, lifeless geometric shapes.

Sophia: Yet, through it all 37 stood unwavering.

Sophia: She poured incredible focus into her mother's research, never displaying any sadness or hesitation.

Sophia: Just like the theorem she spoke of that day on the beach—unchanging, resolute, immune to the passage of time.

Sophia: —How could 37 stay so uniquely unaffected by the world around her?

Sophia: ...

Sophia: I couldn't find an answer to that question; all I could do was offer her my help, meager as it was.

TO BE CONTINUED...

A Children's Game

COL-306602

A Children's Game

Sophia: The lab's light bulb needs changing, and we may need more paper for calculations ...

Sophia: 37 mentioned last time that we need—

Believer II: Oh, hey, Sophia!

Believer II: You look like you're in a rush. something urgent?

Sophia: Not exactly, I'm just heading to the lab to check on 37's progress.

Believer II: 37 ... It's been a while since she's made an appearance on the beach.

Believer I: Perhaps she's still digging into those remaining records? No one else can handle them ...

Every time the "Emanation" came up in conversation, the atmosphere seemed to darken in response.

It was as if navigating around the edge of a storm.

Believer II: Don't worry, 37 will figure it out.

Believer II: And hey, take care of yourselves. Both of you. We don't need you to wear yourselves out ...

Sophia: Thank you both so much.

Sophia: Sophia extended her hand in a gesture of goodwill.

After sharing those brief pleasantries, it was time to continue on their way.

Laboratory, Island

Scattered scribbled notes, piles of thick books, and stray strands of critter hair ...

It looked as if a flock of Abraxas had visited, or the lab had been caught in a whirlwind for centuries on end.

Anyone would have been exhausted by such a sight.

And amidst the panoply the lab director herself lay sprawled across a table, lost in her own head.

Sophia: Umm ... 37 ... Have you considered tidying up this room?

She moved nimbly, stepping over scattered books, as she approached the long table.

The notebook which lay beside 37 looked oddly familiar.

Sophia: Is this ...

Someone had treasured this notebook, adorning it with illustrations and notes.

Flipping through its pages, Sophia found meticulous data validation records accompanied by engineering sketches.

After a few more pages, the content started relating to things on the island, interspersed with sheet music and simple sketches, documenting seagulls flying by and the silhouette of a little girl playing.

Finally, her fingers halted on a page with grids and a few math problems written on it.

Thirty-seven: Oh ... Sophia? You're here!

37 rubbed her eyes and quickly shifted her attention to the notebook Sophia was holding.

Thirty-seven: Oh, I found this little book while looking through the one of these piles!

Thirty-seven: There's an absolute plethora of notes inside. I wanted to see if there were any records relating to the "Emanation".

37 straightened up, carefully inspecting the page Sophia was reading.

Sophia: I remember this page ... I was so young then, standing on my tiptoes to reach my father's desk.

Sophia: I told him how my friend seemed uninterested in games, and that I was struggling with math ...

Sophia: He brought a stool so I could see the words as he wrote in his notebook ...

Sophia: ... Sorry, this isn't really important.

She closed the notebook and turned to 37.

Sophia: These are riddles for kids, far too simple for you.

Sophia: Don't waste time on them ... Everyone's waiting for the next phase of your research.

Sophia: I'll take this notebook with me.

Thirty-seven: No, Sophia! These aren't just for kids—

Thirty-seven: I just found out that the answers form an interesting sequence!

Thirty-seven: They might relate to celestial rhythms, that's Hugh's area of study, right?

Thirty-seven: Look, this number seems to follow an octave pattern with the next one ...

Thirty-seven: And these symbols are unique too!

Thirty-seven: They're all related to the number 3. It must be a trick using a combination of triangles! I've tried several solutions ...

She listed one intriguing discovery after another.

37 pontificated, glowing with increasing focus and enthusiasm.

It was reminiscent of her past lessons on the beach and countless nights researching the "Emanation".

Armed with that intense curiosity, she sought answers in everything.

—Unwavering, unchanging.

Sophia: ... Fine.

Sophia: If that's the case, then I'll help you find the answers, 37.

Sophia: But let's be quick. Afterward, you'll refocus on your main research, right?

Thirty-seven: Of course! It shouldn't take long, I'm almost certain!

Thirty-seven: First, we should find a spacious spot, something close to the one described in the notebook ...

The notebook rustled in 37's hands.

Her fingers skimmed the pages, capturing fleeting sparks of inspiration as she sped toward the lab's exit.

Sophia: Sigh ...

Sophia: I hope this won't take too long ...

Sophia: ... should I really let her waste time like this?

TO BE CONTINUED...

Beach Walking

COL-306603

Beach Walking

Strolling along the familiar path on the beach, everything looked as it did before.

The sand was sand, rocks ... only rocks.

Earthly elements, far divorced from anything transcendental.

But it was an unwritten doctrine of the school —a walk by the sea helped one contemplate the truth.

Sophia: Oh, I missed that flock of seagulls!

Sophia: Careful, 37, next to you—

The startled birds flapped and cawed, shaking off in a flurry of sand and feathers.

37 brushed away the debris that landed on her paper, continuing on without fuss ...

Sophia caught up with her, hurrying from behind, at last breaking her focus.

Thirty-seven: Something wrong, Sophia?

Sophia: Oh- nothing. Any new discoveries?

Thirty-seven: Not yet, but I've thoroughly dispelled the dark clouds from my mind.

The sea breeze may not aid in finding the truth, but it is invigorating, in its own way.

But as if to challenge her claim, a yawn escaped her.

Thirty-seven: So sleepy ...

Child Believer I: Look, it's 37!

Child Believer I: Have you discovered anything interesting lately? Care to tell us about it?

Child Believer II: Perhaps we should we start calling 37 the Star of Hermes, like 210 does?

Child Believer II: I mean, it sounds like an honor doesn't it ... Anyway, good afternoon, 37!

They passed a group of children who overtook them with curiosity and warm greetings.

Everyone had known of 37's curious methods for her research and so few were surprised to see her strolling along the beach with the notebook in hand.

Sophia: Afternoon. Playing hopscotch?

Sophia: Better move a bit further, or the waves will mess up your lines.

Thirty-seven: Waves ... Each drop in the waves moves in a circular motion. When the crest of a wave exceed 120 degrees, they crash with a "whoosh."

Thirty-seven: But the answer sequence seems unrelated with these waves. What could it be then?

She briefly dove back into in her thoughts.

But as their leader approached, she snapped out almost as quickly.

Six: 266, 267 ...

Six: Oh ...

The leader sidestepped them around them silently, as if trying to make a quick escape.

Such efforts rarely turned out as expected for him.

Thirty-seven: 6! You're here too!

Thirty-seven: What methods are you examining with your walk? Are you counting your steps along the beach?

Thirty-seven: Perhaps you are taking 6666 steps because you’re 6? Oh! But that number isn't optimal, let me suggest—

6 deftly avoided 37's quizzical advice and changed the subject.

Six: ... Why aren't you in your laboratory?

Thirty-seven: I discovered some puzzles Hugh left behind, so I’ve opted to decode them with Sophia.

She happily waved the decorated notebook in her hand towards 6.

Sophia: These puzzles are mostly children's games, I can assure you 37 won't waste too much time on them.

Thirty-seven: They are indeed rudimentary!

Thirty-seven: Oh! I've figured out the clue I overlooked! Thank you, Sophia, I have it now!

Thirty-seven: They're games! So you must play through them to understand Hugh's intention!

Thirty-seven: And it just so happens there are already three of us—you, me, and 6—

Imperceptibly, 6's hair stood on end, like a fight or flight response.

Six: Sorry, there are other matters that call to my attention.

Thirty-seven: We used to play together often, didn't we?

Thirty-seven: The present is no different from the past, time is merely a procession of knots on an infinite rope. It doesn't matter where you start counting.

Six: Thank you for your invitation, but ...

As 6 spoke, he took a step back.

The language was clear, implying that the conversation should end there.

Unfortunately, these social cues were lost on 37.

Thirty-seven: Excellent, I'd like to use this beach to gather anyone interested in the game.

Thirty-seven: I assure you it'll be done before dinner—but we simply cannot ignore this pressing issue!

Six: Very well.

6 turned to Sophia, nodding an almost imperceptible plea to her.

Six: Please evaluate the feasibility of 37's proposal.

Six: But I'm afraid I must take my leave.

He took a step forward, pausing for a moment.

Thirty-seven: I'll start from 268.

Six: Thank you.

Finally, he resumed his interrupted walk, narrowly escaping 37's notice as she returned to her thoughts.

Thirty-seven: You know, 6 is the best riddle-solver among us ...

Thirty-seven: He used to say the most interesting things, but now he's become naught but a walking scroll!

Sophia: 6 has become the leader of the school, and our leaders need to be even-handed, objective, forthright ... flawless.

Sophia: 6 has so many obligations. We all have our own tasks that need doing.

Thirty-seven: Well—then, my task is to understand the true meaning behind these exercises!

She raised the collection of children's games high.

For the island's chief researcher, it wasn't the most fitting action.

Sophia: 37 ...

Sophia: Maybe these exercises don't have any meaning at all?

Thirty-seven: Huh?

37 blinked, as if Sophia's words had no imprint of meaning at all.

Sophia: They are just children's games, and you already know the answers to each one of them.

Sophia: I know you think the sequence of answers has some significance, but maybe they are just random numbers. All things considered, we still have—

Their conversation could have carried on about people's expectations, duties, and obligations.

But the sea breeze suddenly drowned out her voice.

37 didn't hear her—or perhaps she didn't care to ...

Thirty-seven: It's those kids, look!

37 looked into the distance, completely engrossed in the next moment.

Thirty-seven: Come on, Sophia, hurry up. I'll help you ask—

Sophia: Hold on, don't go so fast ...

Her words were lost in the swaying of 37's robe as she dashed ahead.

She was always one to act on her thoughts immediately. Seizing on every idea, and squandering her inspiration, yet she could reach heights others only dreamed of.

Not long ago she rushed out of the canteen in the middle of dinner, bewildering everyone present.

But a day later, she submitted her "Initial Speculation on the Distribution of the Emanation", which was just as soon verified.

When asked about it, 37's response was understated—

"Oh, I simply noticed a striking resemblance between the patterns of the Emanation and how my sesame seeds were arranged!"

Sophia: ... It was her strange genius.

She bent down to pick up a pebble buried in the sand and tossed it as far as she could.

As the stone skimmed over the water's surface, it created several ripples, conjuring a stream of memories.

Sophia: Waah ...

Faint sobs collided against the smooth geometric surfaces, leaving faint and hollow echoes.

But a hurried set of footsteps obscured any other sounds.

Thirty-seven: Sophia, you're here!

Thirty-seven: I have something for you, something you'll be interested in!

37 handed over a glass bottle.

The rolled-up paper inside looked jagged, as if it had once been a corner of a worksheet.

Thirty-seven: You wanted to know your soul number, right? I saw it, so I wrote it down here!

Her tone was as proud as ever.

It was a "prime" number, one that carried a meaning of hard and piercing brilliance.

It was a memory that was willfully forgotten.

In the last moments of her memory, the glass bottle traced an arc through the air, landing in the sea.

As the ripples dispersed, calm returned.

Thirty-seven: Sophia, Sophia?

Her friend's call brought her back to reality.

Thirty-seven: There are more people interested in this game than I thought!

In no time, 37 returned with the participants she had found.

Shining with confidence, she seemed ready to start immediately.

Thirty-seven: All the necessary conditions are met now. We need to proceed in order with the game. Let’s start with the first question!

Thirty-seven: Will you help by observing us, Sophia?

Sophia: ... Of course.

Sophia: I'll validate your calculations and check for any errors.

The red-haired Corrector nodded.

Of course, not every question needed an answer.

Now they all had their own tasks.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Answer in a Bottle

COL-306604

Answer in a Bottle

Thirty-seven: How's it going? You’ve followed all the steps in order, right?

Believer II: Yes, I've numbered them and made notes.

Thirty-seven: Wonderful, that will be a most valuable resource!

Thirty-seven: Now on to the second question ...

The women in plain robes continued with the game, methodically going through its motions.

It was nothing more than a simple game for kids.

To the Corrector, it all seemed amusing—here they were brilliant minds meticulously recreating child's play on the beach, instead of tackling the great questions of their age.

Sophia: ... Do you really think this game holds any significance?

As soon as Sophia asked this, the woman recording the answers turned and gave her a smile.

Believer II: Feeling bored?

Sophia: ... No, not really.

Sophia: 37 believes that by completing this game, she'll understand some hidden meaning in the sequence formed by the answers ...

Sophia: But my father was pragmatic, and always focused on the present. Like me, he didn't have an eye for these sorts of abstract things.

Sophia: I doubt his notebook could contain any of the transcendental meanings 37 is seeking.

Believer II: Hmm ... Honestly, at first glance, you can easily see the results.

Believer II: The answers to each question form a ten-digit number, 6333434533.

Believer II: I can't see its value, but 37 must be doing this for a reason.

Believer II: After all, she's always the first to grasp the "essence" beyond our understanding.

Sophia: Essence ...

She had never associated her father's notebook with the notion of some transcendental essence.

What "essence" could a set of children's exercises in an old book possibly hold?

Sophia: If this is just a waste of time it could erode everyone's trust ...

Sophia: Then I ...

The Corrector furrowed her brow with worry.

She felt as if she had to rectify this mistake.

Thirty-seven: Sophia, what's on your mind?

Her friend's sudden appearance caught her off guard, forcing her to take a step back.

Sophia: ... Oh—nothing.

She forced an adjustment of her demeanor, hiding any sign of her flustered thoughts.

Sophia: I was just thinking, 37. Are these game perhaps too simple for the others?

Thirty-seven: Are they?

37 tilted her head.

Thirty-seven: But there is nothing simple about any set of numbers, nor any set of answers!

Thirty-seven: Indeed the simplest numbers often hold the deepest meaning. Even a number as singular as"1", holds the origin of all mathematical thought.

Thirty-seven: I believe the problems in this notebook are no different!

Sophia: ... Of course, you're always right, 37.

Sophia: But perhaps instead of these simple games, we could—

Thirty-seven: Work on more important things?

37 finished her sentence, catching the red-headed Corrector off guard once again.

37's eyes followed her as she took a step forward and fired off a series of questions of her own.

Thirty-seven: Sophia, you keep repeating yourself.

Thirty-seven: —So then, what's most important to you?

Sophia: ... !

There could be many answers—their research on the "Emanation", the school's public affairs, or perhaps even just the fate of this small island.

But—

Sophia: No, go away, 37!

Sophia: I know you're right, you're always right. But I don't want to know!

Sophia: I don't want to know my number anymore—

The glass bottle shattered the water's surface, the splash rang heavy and bitter.

Sophia: ...

Sophia: I'm sorry ...

They both knew the ancient instruction, "Know thyself."

But the most important answer had already been swept away by the waves, lost in the endless depths of the sea.

Sophia: ...

Sophia: ... Sorry, 37 ... I don't know that I can answer you right now.

Sophia: It's such a profound question, and I don't have an easy answer ...

Sophia: I suppose I need some time to think about it properly.

Sophia: —I need to check our inventory. I hope your research goes well, 37—

She spoke the words quickly feigning calm.

But it wasn't so easy to turn and leave; 37 held Sophia's hand firmly.

Thirty-seven: Someone once taught me a problem-solving technique—when you're at a loss, try changing your mood.

Thirty-seven: It's a useful trick. One which I've tested many times.

Thirty-seven: If you don't have anything more important to do now, why not play the game with us?

Thirty-seven: You still haven't participated in Hugh's game yet!

Sophia: ...

It was always so impossible to let go of that hand.

Sophia: Alright ... But remember, you promised to finish before dinner.

Thirty-seven: Of course! Anyway, 6 is still walking around the island. We have time before he reaches four digits!

Thirty-seven: Come on, Sophia, let's tackle the next question—

Behind the Puzzle

COL-306605

Thirty-seven: Sophia, was the game helpful at all?

37 rushed over as Sophia descended from the "playground".

Thirty-seven: Were the problems fun, inspiring, or perhaps dull?

Thirty-seven: Should the results be logged or just discarded in a corner of the lab?

Sophia: Well, they weren't as dull as I expected. Breaking down the logic was pretty straightforward ...

Sophia: For a kid just arriving on the island, it's a decent puzzle.

Sophia: If I'd played these as a kid, I might have warmed up to math more—perhaps I'd even have understood the whole "everything is numbers" thing a little sooner.

Sophia: But in the here and now, they don't feel very practical, nor enlightening.

Thirty-seven: Oh ... I see.

Thirty-seven: No luck, it seems. What could we be missing?

With obvious disappointment, 37 flipped through the notebook once more, diving deep into her thoughts again.

It was getting dark, and the others began leaving the beach.

It seemed 37's games didn't yield any results.

For her assistant, this seemed like the expected outcome—these games appeared to be more of a basic educational tool than something profound.

Thirty-seven: Hmmm—

Sophia: It's time for dinner, we've run out of the time we requested from 6—there's ...

Thirty-seven: No, wait ... ! It's not over until I go for dinner ...

37 stared at the grid lines on the beach, as if she was rooted there.

The puzzle represented by these numbers would be on her mind all night, replacing thoughts of roasted rabbit and honeyed bread.

Although it was clear that this number sequence didn't hold any profound meaning at first glance, what if everyone just hadn't looked deep enough?

Sophia: ...

Sophia: ... I have some free time tomorrow morning. Maybe we can give it another shot then.

Sophia: When Apollo first rides out chasing the dawn, we might discover a fresh perspective.

Thirty-seven: ... ?! Do you think so?!

Sophia: Otherwise, you'd stay here all night?

Sophia sighed, once again realizing she was indulging 37.

Sophia: I don't understand, 37. Why are you so convinced there's some hidden significance in this sequence of answers?

Thirty-seven: Huh? Because it's right there!

Thirty-seven: I feel it, if only vaguely. When Hugh jotted down these numbers, they contained a strong emotion ...

Sophia: ... So, you're going with your intuition?

Sophia: Intuition ...

At the mention of that word, the girl's expression dimmed.

Back in her childhood before she came to the island, when she was known as an "arcanist", she was familiar with this term.

Sensing, listening, understanding, beseeching, being fiercely focused, and seizing inspiration. It was all familiar to her.

But she couldn't see the flash of genius whenever she pleased, playing around with them as if she was catching butterflies.

What did having such an ability really mean?

Thirty-seven: Sophia—come on!

Thirty-seven: If you don't get to the canteen now, only the soup base will be left!

37 had maneuvered nimbly over a line of seagull footprints, and waved to beckon Sophia ahead.

Sophia: ...

Sophia: Ho ... Hold on, I'm coming!

And remember, not every question needs an answer.

We have more important things to do now.

TO BE CONTINUED...

What Was Not Expressed

COL-306606

What Was Not Expressed

Mornings on the beach were meant for quiet strolls and relaxation.

Sophia's plan to arrive early and clear her mind seemed wise,

but things rarely went as expected here.

Thirty-seven: Sophia, you’re late!

Thirty-seven: I've been here since Apollo rose to meet the dawn!

The crowd surrounding 37 seemed even larger than yesterday as she hopped and waved at Sophia.

At the center of the crowd was another familiar figure.

210: Ah, good, the Corrector's here too? What perfect timing.

210: Hey everyone, come gather around and take a look.

210 was holding up a magazine.

210: —My submission isn't any more childish than this game she's playing!

Some chuckled—it was a common occurrence for the islanders familiar with their banter.

210 confidently presented the magazine to Sophia and 37.

The magazine pages were a mess. Amid frivolous news and various announcements, a crumpled mathematical proof huddled in a corner.

Fortunately, the author was still identifiable.

Sophia: "A Treatise on the Linguistic Structure of Truth"—210, is that your name?

The towering Theorist just spread his hands out in an over-proud twist without confirming.

210: Certainly it was no easy feat given our island's isolation, to get this published … But where there is a will there is a way.

210: Submitting these mathematical essays to outside publications is just the beginning of my many accomplishments to come.

Believer I: I think he's over-blowing the difficulty of reaching out.

Sophia: And is this really a mathematical treatise … seems like a lot of words.

Sophia flipped through the magazine quickly, it was nothing more than a common railway journal.

210's essay was listed in the "Excerpts and Anecdotes" column.

Sophia: To publish a paper on truth in a magazine like this … Huh … The editor's comment is, "Although the content is obscure, the wording is elegant and worth citing."

Sophia: That's impressive, nonetheless.

The compliment was genuine, and the already haughty Theorist's confidence grew even more.

37 though crossed her arms in a breathless huff.

Thirty-seven: I've read that article. It's pure sophistry! Your premise is flawed and the central thesis over-complicated!

Thirty-seven: The beauty of mathematical truth lies in its simplicity. These nonsensical embellishments only lead to misinterpretation!

Thirty-seven: It's cumbersome, frivolous, and most importantly, it lacks good process.

Thirty-seven: This is all just clever rhetoric, lacking in any substance!

Thirty-seven: Wasted space and meaningless platitudes.

210: Is that so? More meaningless than all this child's play.

210: Or perhaps this game is simple enough for you? Are these piddling lessons in basic reasoning and arithmetic the truth you are looking for?

210: Well, that makes sense for a child. Carry on with your fun and games then.

The children on the beach had eagerly gathered around 210, forming a lively crowd.

At an age when curiosity reigns, they were always interested in this kind of biting debate.

The arguments, conflicts, grandeur, and aspirations converged on a single number.

Thirty-seven: 210.

Thirty-seven: Your numbers clearly contain 2, 3, 5, and 7.

Thirty-seven: You've just lumped them together without using them effectively.

210: Oh, so now you're accusing me of being insincere? That I'm making frivolous gestures only to flaunt my intelligence.

210: —How very logical of you …

210: But all this debate allows me to speak the truth that the other's are concealing from you.

210: These are games for children, 37.

210: There are no revelations to be gleaned from your stubbornly pursuing some childish arithmetic?

210: Oh but we all trust the brilliance of our Star of Hermes and oh-so willingly serve as a companion star under your guidance. But, surely our brilliant star should consider others' duties and responsibilities, no?

Thirty-seven: …

Sophia stepped in, breaking the tension at just the right moment.

Sophia: Don't be so serious, 210. We're just passing the time before breakfast with some games, and 37 isn't forcing anyone else to join in.

Sophia: But I agree, perhaps these games are too simple. In your opinion, what changes would it need?

210: Obviously, the questions should be harder, more fitting our caliber, and there should be scores and rankings, and some sort of elimination and revival mechanism.

210: All the participants should be grouped on the beach, competing in groups of three, and special areas and specific time slots should be scheduled—

Thirty-seven: What? Absolutely not!

37 forcefully interrupted 210's excited rule making.

Thirty-seven: This game and its questions were left behind by Hugh for a reason! It's simple because it was designed for children!

Thirty-seven: I don't want to compete with anyone; I just want to understand the hidden meanings within the sequence of answers Hugh left!

Thirty-seven: Of course, if it were more complex, then the participants might enjoy the thrill of its intellectual pursuit …

Thirty-seven: But the beauty of the game lies in its simplicity, just like numbers themselves.

Thirty-seven: Stripped of all embellishments, "1" is "1".

Thirty-seven: People, stones, trees, and physical things decay, deteriorate, and change, but "1" remains.

Thirty-seven: This is a simple game, yet it holds the most wonderful wisdom.

Thirty-seven: There's no need to make the simple so complicated. All these facades may grab attention, but it strays from the game's true essence.

210: So you yourself admit it's dull and monotonous.

210: I simply articulated the same meaning with words to made them more convincing, without distorting the truth.

Some of his followers in the crowd nodded as they listened.

They were captivated by his rebuttal.

Such analysis, discussions, and endless numbers was an every day occurrence in this school of thought.

37's response was to draw several squares on the beach.

Thirty-seven: I learned about this from Sophia.

Thirty-seven: "Hopscotch" is a popular children's game elsewhere.

Thirty-seven: The rules are simple; one hops from one end to the other. It was easy enough to learn, and I've never forgotten it.

210: So our star has learned hopscotch? I hope you weren't expecting surprise ...

Thirty-seven: No, I mean, it's easy to play because of its simplicity.

Thirty-seven: For this reason, it spread from where Sophia was before, and now the children on our island play it too.

The group of children who played on the beach yesterday began to laugh.

Child Believer I: That's right!

Child Believer II: 37's game is fun too.

37 acknowledged her young supporters and carried on.

Thirty-seven: If we complicate the game Hugh that designed with new rules and competition, won't we lose its true essence?

It was a splendid debate, and some followers had already started betting seashells on which side would win.

On the island, such debates might continue from early morning until the time of silence.

If that were to happen, 37's game would be unable to continue, and more important research would tragically remain on hold.

The Corrector felt the need to intervene.

Sophia: Both sides brought strong points. I believe—

210: You're right.

Sophia: Yes, of course, 37 is right—about what, exactly?

210: As you said, it's a children's game; its essence cannot and will not change. I'm curious, though, about what insights you can glean from such "simplicity".

210: Everyone can see the answers at a glance, yet you believe there's some "profound meaning" in this combination of answers—

210 spread his hands in a mocking gesture and shrugged.

210: It's just time wasted, nothing compared to the pivotal proof uncovered by our great Star of Hermes.

210: Go on, figure out how much this children's game is worth caring about.

210: I'm eager to see the outcome.

Just Numbers

COL-306607

Just Numbers

The sight in front of them seemed much like it always did.

The salty breeze and the grains of sand carried by it.

Two figures strolled hand in hand.

No one cared about the children sneaking away from the congregation. They just had to be careful to avoid getting caught.

Sophia: Wow, this place is so beautiful and wide. It's much bigger than my yard back home!

Sophia: Have you ever played hopscotch?

Sophia pointed towards several lines drawn in the sand with shells.

Together, the lines formed clumsy squares.

Sophia: Jump from here to there, but don't step on the lines or squash the shells.

Sophia: I used to play this game before I came to the island. It's different from hide-and-seek; you can play it alone too ...

Thirty-seven: That sounds fun!

Thirty-seven: But I can't understand the meaning of the lines ... They don't form a pattern I can recognize.

Thirty-seven: Maybe I need more time to understand their meaning.

37 playfully kicked up some sand, twirling around.

Thirty-seven: Why do we only jump on the squares?

Thirty-seven: Adding a nine-point circle to this game would be nice!

Thirty-seven: Four inscribed circles, twelve tangential circles—it'd be amazing if you only jumped from the points ...

She shared her thoughts, trying to convey what she saw in her mind's eye.

Her tone grew earnest and persistent, trying to illustrate the things she imagined.

Yet, it was like endlessly picking up shiny pebbles on the beach ...

... just like today.

Thirty-seven: 210 always tries to make simple things complicated. Hugh just wanted us to finish the game's problems—

Thirty-seven: Well? Of course, the scripture say: "One who does not divide the problem into three parts cannot achieve true wisdom."

Thirty-seven: But that's no reason to propose three-player matches!

The present scene intertwined seamlessly with past memories, unaffected by time.

Sophia: Ha-ha!

The girl's rare smile piqued her companion's curiosity and she came over.

Thirty-seven: Sophia, what's on your mind?

Thirty-seven: What's made you so happy?

Sophia: I was thinking, since the "Emanation", we've hardly ever gathered together like this.

Sophia: 6 became 6, you've taken over your mother's research, and 210 is always so busy with his proofs and fraternizing.

Sophia: Even discussions like the one we just had happen so rarely now.

Sophia: Yet after all this time, you remain so resolute.

Sophia: It's like you never changed.

Thirty-seven: Hmph! Maybe you haven't noticed, but I have changed.

Raising her hand high, 37 gestured from the ground to her head.

Thirty-seven: I've grown taller than before.

Thirty-seven: And my hair's longer and harder to manage now.

Thirty-seven: It takes much longer for you to comb it.

Sophia: Not these surface-level changes, 37 ...

Thirty-seven: Oh, then I'm not quite sure what you mean.

Thirty-seven: Never mind that—I need your help, Sophia!

Thirty-seven: We're down to the last two questions, just a stone's throw from the answer.

Thirty-seven: I was hoping we could finish it together.

Just Numbers

COL-306608

Closing her notebook, 37 felt every detail course through her body.

The result was clear; from the beginning, everyone could see the number laid bare on the paper.

Thirty-seven: 6333434533.

A composite number divisible by 41, its largest prime factor was 154474013.

If you saw it as a sequence, it was a simple combination of 3, 4, 5, and 6. 3 appeared 6 times, 4 appeared twice, while 5 and 6 appeared once each.

Thirty-seven: Whether you look at it as a number or a sequence, it still feels like something is missing ...

Thirty-seven: Hugh's annotated shapes must hold the key.

Thirty-seven: I just haven't figured out what those little points mean yet.

37 pointed to an ink blotch on the notebook directly under a hexagon.

210: It's just an accidental smear.

Thirty-seven: But look, there's the same mark below this question later on too.

210: Sometimes, for convenience, they put a dot over repeating decimals in infinite series.

210: That dot's above, but this one's below—perhaps Sophia's father thought 6 had its limitations?

Thirty-seven: That makes no sense, it can't be.

210: Having a sense of humor every now and then wouldn't hurt.

He shrugged, pretending indifference to 37's rebuttal.

Thirty-seven: I admit I overcomplicated Hugh's marks at first.

Thirty-seven: There are so many possible attributes that they easily steered my thinking in the wrong direction ...

210: Remember what you said to me earlier: "Don't complicate simple things."

210: Maybe there's no deep meaning in these symbols—maybe you've just made it complex.

Thirty-seven: No, absolutely not! Hugh didn't leave these marks at random.

Thirty-seven: Look, only the questions whose answer is the number 3 have this kind of pattern.

Thirty-seven: It's a small puzzle related to the number of triangles.

Sophia: My father did love geometric shapes. I think 37 might be onto something.

Feeling supported, 37 confidently continued.

Thirty-seven: I thought if I experienced the game firsthand, I'd understand the meaning behind these marks and sequences …

Thirty-seven: But I still don't get it.

Thirty-seven: There's something missing here, and it's because I don't understand Hugh well enough. If I were Sophia—

210: Oh, so the conclusion is there's no secret to this game after all?

210: In that case, it looks like I've won.

Thirty-seven: Don't be so hasty, 210!

Thirty-seven: The scripture say the learned remain silent. They listen attentively and take others' words seriously.

Thirty-seven: So perhaps you will show yourself to be a proper learned scholar and let me finish without interruption?!

210: The teachings also exhort us to listen to the sound of the wind.

210: They demand that we earnestly listen to everything to expand our thinking—Have you considered that I too am a part of "everything"?

210: Think about your argument—simple games can hold the most beautiful wisdom.

210: Yet now you realize that this wisdom eludes you because you don't understand Hugh well enough.

210: Can't you see, 37? I don't even need to knock your castle down; it's already a puddle of quicksand.

210 sarcastically shook his head implying that the conclusion was self-evident.

Unyielding, 37 crossed her arms.

Thirty-seven: More meaningless rhetoric!

210: Calm down and let me explain.

210: The beauty of wisdom should apply to everyone, yet you want to uncover truths through personal relationships.

210: Maybe this sequence indeed holds meaning, but perhaps it's just a personal note Hugh gave to his daughter. After all, it's not a collection of axioms; it's a personal notebook.

210: These numbers might only hold meaning for Hugh and Sophia. But what use do you have for them?

210: The scripture also says: "Do not easily extend your right hand to others." In other words, one should attend to their own affairs.

210: Yet, the Star of Hermes eagerly takes away others' proofs and treats them as her playthings.

210: Aren't the materials left by your mother enough to pass the time?

210's mockery was evident in his words.

But his opponent remained steadfast.

Thirty-seven: No, the teachings mean that we shouldn't easily impart wisdom and knowledge to those who don't appreciate it. You've twisted its meaning!

Thirty-seven: Once you enter the temple, you cannot turn back. In the pursuit of truth, insufficient knowledge is worse than total ignorance.

Thirty-seven: Since I've begun exploring this, how can I stop halfway?

Thirty-seven: And the meaning of numbers isn't determined by anyone! They exist, unrelated to time, space, or who we are.

Thirty-seven: They're not someone's property!

Thirty-seven: If none of us know the sequence, how can we assert its nature?

The conversation veered again towards an endless back and forth.

Sophia: Oh no ...

The Corrector felt torn, caught between the two.

Mediating disputes was her strength, but this seemed despite their emotions, to be a well-reasoned debate.

Maybe she should leave them to exhaust the truth, it aligned more with their scholarly approach.

As she pondered this, 37 suddenly turned to her.

Thirty-seven: In that case, let Sophia be the judge!

Thirty-seven: Uncover the secrets in the notebook and see who's right.

210: I agree, let the Corrector determine the truth!

Sophia: ... Oh, so this is how it's going to be?

She sighed, regretting her momentary hesitation.

It would be too difficult to refuse the expectant gazes of her friends.

Sophia: Fine, I'll make the judgement.

Sophia: First, let me go over the game properly ...

TO BE CONTINUED...

Sand and Gold

COL-306609

Sand and Gold

Sophia: This island holds so many quirks ...

Sophia: ... and 37 possesses the greatest of them all.

Sophia: She was born with her own set of numbers, always clear about where she's headed.

Sophia: When she speaks of those never-ending numbers on the beach, those beautiful proofs ...

Sophia: It feels like coming face to face with eternity.

Sophia: At the same time, I deeply understand my own simplicity and ordinariness.

Sophia: There's nothing wrong with letting the stars shine where they should, and those who look up will continue to look up.

Sophia: Tidying the lab, managing her hair, listing supplies, receiving guests ...

Sophia: There's no need for these little things to occupy 37's attention. Her time should be spent on more significant research.

Sophia: But beyond all that, 37 is like a bright star, newly born.

Sophia: She disregards conventions, is curious about many new things, and has a playful, carefree spirit.

Sophia: ... Just like any other childhood friend.

Sophia: 37 has her own pursuits ...

Sophia: And I have a task to complete—verify the answers 37 gives.

Sophia: ...

She touched her father's notebook, closing her eyes.

She remembered many vivid fragments.

Sifting sands on the beach, the sting of her fingers as she polished his lenses,

the fragrance of cinnamon and chickpeas lingering in the air.

A ship cleaves through the water's surface, approaching the shore, before disintegrating amid fading cheers.

Then, everything moved forward. Beyond the surging waves, back to humble streets.

Memories from beyond the island that belonged exclusively to Sophia, reaching back to her blurry childhood impressions.

She was different from that lone star, suspended in the sky. She was born to the tangible and belonged to this dim world of phenomena.

She rummaged through her jar of memories, in search of some trinket worthy of trading for a coin.

Indeed, she was a diligent, serious girl.

And so, after examining every small stone in the jar, she finally found a satiating answer.

Sophia: ... I understand now.

Sophia: 6333434533.

Sophia: This isn't just a string of numbers, a sequence, a proverb, or some new truth we've yet to comprehend ...

Sophia: It's a musical score.

Thirty-seven: ... A musical score ... ? What's that?

The word wasn't within 37's scope of thought.

She widened her eyes in surprise, showing her curiosity plainly.

Sophia: People often use this method to notate melodies. This musical score is the beginning of a song.

Sophia: It's quite a popular tune in my hometown, one which my father loved to hum ...

Sophia: ... He must have poured his heart into these questions.

Sand and Gold

COL-306610

If she could just recall the initial notes, the subsequent phrases would naturally follow.

At first stumbling and hoarse, soon the song became fluent, resonating across the quiet beach.

Thirty-seven: I knew numbers could be music, but why didn't I think of it earlier—I was so close!

Thirty-seven: A musical score … but I've never heard of this notation method!

37 didn't stay low for long; she quickly perked up, genuinely praising her companion's revelation.

Thirty-seven: That's a lovely song; and you sing it well, Sophia.

210: I suppose everyone got what they wanted.

210: You've solved the puzzle, Sophia uncovered the song her father left behind …

210: … And I won.

Thirty-seven: Why?! My initial theory was correct; this string of numbers did have a deeper meaning after all!!

210: But you glossed over the musical score.

210: As I foresaw, this had nothing to do with you from the start.

210: It's just a distant hometown ballad that a father left for his daughter, with no profound meaning, no wonderful wisdom, no transcendent truth.

210: But you just had to whimsically stir things up again to satisfy your curiosity.

210: Everything tilts around you, regardless of whether it gets disturbed, shattered—or at times accomplished.

210: That's the genius the people talk about.

210: But don't worry, my words are just inconsequential grains of sand compared to you, the Star of Hermes, the golden treasures are buried in this endless beach, aren't they?

210: Everyone's willing to play along; after all, flocking to a genius is much more interesting than following an ordinary person.

Thirty-seven: But I played the game and verified it …

Thirty-seven: And I told Sophia there must be a secret in the notebook.

Thirty-seven: I …

This was a rare moment—37 was at a loss for words.

Bewildered, she looked at Sophia with a furrowed brow, hoping to hear a judgment strong enough to defeat 210.

Sophia: I agree … 210 has won.

Thirty-seven: … ?!

Thirty-seven: Ah … alright.

Her shoulders slumped as all the inspiration that had driven her thus far vanished in a breath.

This time, 37 didn't perk up again.

Instead she hung her head and kicked at some sand, before burying her head in her robe like a seabird.

Sophia: It's true … This notebook doesn't contain the wondrous wisdom of the scriptures.

Sophia: The string of numbers could only be solved by me, because others didn't know Hugh.

Sophia: 210 was the first to predict this result, that's undeniable.

Sophia: —But I still believe that 37 achieved her goal too.

Sophia's words spared 37 from sinking deeper into the shallow holes she'd already made in the sand with her feet.

She froze, waiting to hear what Sophia was going to say next.

Sophia: No matter what you think, it was 37 who first uncovered these numbers, bringing this memory back to me.

Sophia: If it wasn't for her determination, I wouldn't have had the chance to hear this song again.

Sophia: ... I still remember what 37 told me, about the proof of the existence of infinite prime numbers.

Thirty-seven: Hmm ... ?

Sophia smiled at her, as 37 nodded both enthusiastic and confused.

Sophia: My father, Hugh, was a Corrector like me. He was the previous person responsible for handling matters off the island.

But over time, his name faded into obscurity, leaving behind only a sharp-edged cube, a dusty notebook, and a pair of broken glasses.

Sophia: Like the formula 37 once etched on the beach, his memory has long been washed away by the waves.

Sophia: Although Hugh's spirit has returned to its source ...

Sophia: We can still hear the melody he left behind.

Sophia: Perhaps the one who first sang this song has been swept away by time, faded into nothingness ...

Sophia: But his notes still echo into eternity.

Sophia: Just as we recall the proof Euclid penned over two thousand years ago.

Sophia: Like 37 said, the power of proof lies in its simplicity and universality.

Sophia: This tune holds a certain universality too.

Sophia: Yes, it's not a mathematical theory in the truest sense, and it doesn't speak to the essence—

Sophia: It's only a gleaming shard left by Hugh like grains of sand reflecting faint light on the shore.

Sophia: Yet, this universality allows it to persist through time, crossing vast spaces, and arriving at this moment and place.

Sophia: Let's take a moment to listen to this song.

Sophia: To simply listen.

The disputes and differences dissolved in the soft breath of the breeze.

The beach returned to silence; and only the melody lingered.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Endless Shoreline

COL-306611

Endless Shoreline

Sophia: I used to think other people's opinions didn't matter to 37.

Sophia: Even in the most heated arguments, she never paid them much attention.

Sophia: With ordinary eyes, it's difficult to perceive changes in the vastness beyond us.

Sophia: But now I understand how to notice them. The faint scrape of fingers brushing over geometry, the different grains of sand I scoop up when I bend over.

Sophia: The changes are slow and gradual, but they're there.

Apollo's star had risen high, and the Star of Hermes's game had ended.

It was time to head back to that room filled with scattered papers.

Sophia: ... ? 37, what's on your mind?

37's steps were unusually slow. She wondered if the verdict had hit her harder than she predicted.

The ever-scrupulous Corrector began to regret her decision—perhaps it would have been better for 6 to maintain the balance.

Thirty-seven: ... Sophia.

37 started somberly, her words flatter than usual.

Thirty-seven: I hope I didn't waste your time.

Thirty-seven: Do you think it was all just a pointless game?

The doubts spilled out of her, eagerly awaiting an answer.

Sophia: Of course not! That song means a lot to me, it's a precious memory.

Sophia: Are you upset, 37? You didn't seem so down when we listened to the song earlier.

Thirty-seven: Well, that's because it had such a lovely cadence, and you sang it so well!

Her praise came sincerely and quickly, no doubt about it.

Thirty-seven: But what surprised me was when you mentioned that proof about infinite primes ...

Thirty-seven: I remember it, but I have no idea when I told you about it.

Sophia: ...

Sophia: Of course, I remember, 37. It was a beautiful proof.

Sophia: I'll always remember it.

But that didn't comfort her much. Distractedly, 37 grabbed at her hair.

Thirty-seven: ... So, have I messed up your memories of Hugh?

Thirty-seven: Barging in disrupting your memories, and leaving a mess behind ...

Sophia widened her eyes slightly.

Sophia: ...

Sophia: 37, are you still bothered by what 210 said?

She averted her eyes—that was rare.

Sophia: ... Hahaha!

Thirty-seven: Sophia, what's so funny!?

Sophia: Sorry ... I just never thought I'd see you care about something he said.

Sophia: You're right, you really have changed a lot after all.

Thirty-seven: Of course! Didn't I tell you that?

Thirty-seven: It's not just my height ... I've even changed where I sit at the table.

Thirty-seven: As the distance between me and the table changes, so does the best angle for catching the sun.

Sophia: I'm not talking about height or seats ...

Sophia shook her head with a soft smile.

It was a gentle, rare, loving gesture.

Sophia: 37, do you know why I've never forgotten that proof about infinite primes?

Sophia: Because it made me ponder such distant things for the first time.

Sophia: Before, I didn't care about what "eternity" meant; it felt like nothing. Some far away notion.

Sophia: Now I stand here, fully aware that the island under our feet will one day disappear, washed away like sand by the tide.

Sophia: —But I also believe some things will endure, like grains of gold buried in the silt.

The island was vast enough to house an entire school of thought.

Yet it was also so small, a speck in the waves.

And we, living amidst it, could only remember fleeting moments.

Thirty-seven: Yes, because the world we see is transient.

37 nodded seriously; this topic was more familiar to her than discussing dinner plans.

Sophia: You shared it with me because of the eternity and beauty that the infinite holds, and its universally true nature. From then on, I've seen the gold in the sands.

Sophia: And in turn, I shared Hugh's song with you. If it brought you joy, that means it has meaning for you too.

Sophia: Maybe it's not the transcendent essence you were seeking. But those who hear the song will feel it, remember it—maybe even hum it one day.

Sophia: That is universal beauty too.

Thirty-seven: ... ! So that's it—I get it now!

The confusion vanished from 37's face, and she returned all at once to her usual cheerful self.

Thirty-seven: This song isn't just for Hugh and Sophia anymore because you shared it with us ... right?

Thirty-seven: So it's universal and belongs to everyone who hears it! Just like the proof I shared with you!

Thirty-seven: ... Why are you laughing again, Sophia?

Sophia: ... Oh, it's nothing.

Sophia: I'm just thinking about how you're always turning everything into a proof to understand it ...

Sophia: When it's as simple as enjoying music with friends.

Thirty-seven: ... Hmm!

Thirty-seven: I suppose I still can't quite grasp this kind of simplicity ...

37 thought hard about this, puzzling over it like a new problem.

But thankfully, she soon had a new idea, as always.

Thirty-seven: "Sharing" is really a solid argument—I bet 210 would struggle to argue against it!

Thirty-seven: I knew my viewpoint was right! I'm going to tell him right away!

Sophia: ...

37 hurried off and caught up with 210, who was leafing through another magazine.

210: What now? Sophia's declared I won and nothing can change that.

Thirty-seven: You were just a spectator, making random guesses, while I uncovered a valuable song!

210: Believe what you want—I've said enough today; I'd like a bit of peace and quiet now.

He deliberately slowed down, trailing behind Sophia and 37.

37 took it as 210 conceding, and her steps became light as air.

Thirty-seven: Well, except for some trivial details, everything went smoothly today.

Thirty-seven: It's the number "9", the trinity of peace, friendship, and harmony. Absolutely perfect.

Thirty-seven: Oh, that's right!

37 turned to Sophia with a sudden recollection, a joyful smile spreading across her face.

Thirty-seven: Come on, Sophia, give me your hand—

Thirty-seven: This is for you.

The feathers, shells, and pebbles formed a lovely decorative chain.

There was a lone pebble next to it.

Sophia: ... Is this for me?

Thirty-seven: Of course! And this one, I found it on the beach just now.

Thirty-seven: The pattern forms a fantastic number! You can add it to the chain or, you know, give it a toss into the waves!

Sophia: ...

Sophia: Thanks, 37.

Thirty-seven: I came to the beach this morning to give it to you.

Thirty-seven: But I found myself sidetracked and completely forgot ...

Sophia: That's alright, 37, I really appreciate your gift.

Thirty-seven: That's great! Shall we hang out again tomorrow, Sophia? I'll catch up with my research in no time.

Thirty-seven: Oh, the day after tomorrow could work too. We could make this a regular island activity —

Sophia: ...

Now was the time, relaxed and pleasant enough, for her to ask what she had left unsaid.

Sophia: 37, do all these numbers have this infinite meaning to you?

Thirty-seven: Of course.

37 answered without missing a beat.

Sophia: So 37 is just one number in the infinite progression?

Thirty-seven: If it's not, what else could it be?

Thirty-seven: 210, 37, 6 ... Even if we're gone, these numbers won't disappear.

Thirty-seven: Just like you don't need three seagulls, three stones, or three people to prove the number three exists.

Thirty-seven: Numbers exist outside of all that.

Sophia: ...

Sophia: Thanks, 37. I think I understand your answer.

Sophia: I've got some other things to take care of. Let's hang out later if there's time.

Thirty-seven: Deal!

Thirty-seven: Wait, I see 6 coming back!

37 waved at the dot on the horizon, as a seagull swooped above them.

She sprang up, greeting the leader.

Thirty-seven: Good morning, 6! 210 and I had a disagreement over something ...

Thirty-seven: But the sequence, it's connected to a song ...

Six: I'm afraid I don't know much about songs.

Thirty-seven: But it's only logical, isn't it?

Thirty-seven: Is there any doctrine from our past that fits this situation?

Six: ...

Six: Thinking things through can help purify one's intellect.

Six: Perhaps a period of quiet contemplation would be helpful.

Thirty-seven: That doesn't suit me well, I'm afraid. Alright, I'll come up with more convincing new arguments on my own.

It was clear that 37 wasn't satisfied with 6's suggestion.

The debate would keep going in the coming days.

Sophia: Watch your step, or you'll trip.

Thirty-seven: Don't worry. As long as I stick to the right order of steps, I won't fall!

210: Don't forget, we've got to hurry or we'll miss mealtime.

210: That seagull looks as starved as her.

Thirty-seven: We could calculate the seagull's speed by counting steps ...

Thirty-seven: Where did we stop counting?

210: You can spend all day counting seagulls on the beach tomorrow.

210: That could be the topic for my next essay.

Thirty-seven: Planning to cover up a weak argument with a bunch of superfluous dribble again?

Sophia: Alright, you two let's pick up the pace.

Sophia: There are other ways to figure out its speed.

Six: 284 steps.

Thirty-seven: Thanks, 6!

Thirty-seven: And the time it took us to get here is ...

THE END